Mainspring

You have your time; will you waste it?
An Isometric Action-Adventure Game about Responsibility, Time, and Companionship

By Luke Pierson

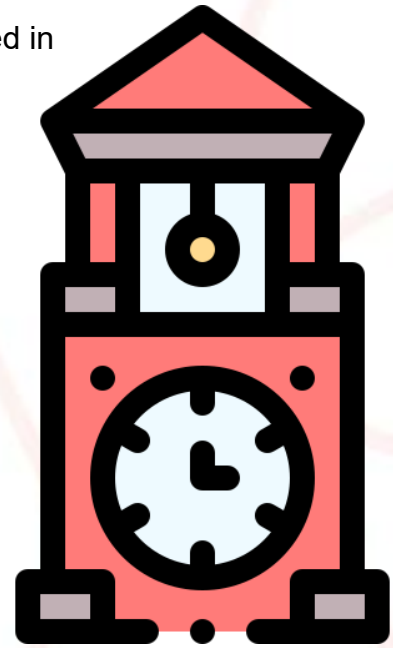
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Game Overview

Game Concept



Mainspring takes mechanics that are typically taken for granted in an action-adventure game and turns them into a scarce resource. Almost everything in Mainspring can only be done at a certain time and takes a certain amount of time, including simple things like basic attacking. The player will learn how to use and organise their kit best to make the most out of limited time they have!

Mainspring takes place in a world of machinery where the core of the clocktower has grown worn, causing people to slowly lose themselves while decay spreads throughout the world. The citizens inhabiting the clocktower don't seem to be willing enough to fix it - wasting time and avoiding responsibility rather than solving the problem. Every resident is some sort of machine, and all have high sentience as if they were a human. The player also being a machine has the goal to reach the top to solve the issue.

Genre

The game takes on an isometric view, action-adventure genre at its core with optional challenges and puzzles to break up tension and build the story of the greater world. There is also a large amount of story in the game to provide emotion and depth to the world. The game revolves around snappy responsive combat, constantly keeping the player on their toes. As well as this, the game has a loose rhythm aspect to it as the music sinks up to the pacing and flow of combat.

Target Audience

There will be no gore as every character and enemy will be some sort of machinery, this makes it appropriate for 7+ audiences. However, the story of the game and characters will have a lot of existential undertones about generational disparity, responsibility, motivation, mental health, and death. It is recommended 12+ due to these reasons.

It will be targeted for those who are large fans of action-adventure games and want a balance of difficulty and world building! Gaming enthusiasts who are looking for a fresh take of common video game mechanics and want a complete deep story to couple with the fulfilment of completing the game. Although it will not be the hardest game in existence, it will provide enough challenge to make players really analyse their own strategies and preparation, so they feel accomplished.

Game Flow Summary

The flow will be **more linear focused.** Optional puzzles and stories will grant additional abilities to allow the player to be more versatile with their kit. The world is split into **4 large sections,** each one surrounding a character (known as a Keysmith) that holds the key to the next area. Each section resembles a certain age demographic (teenager, young adult, middle age and elder) and how they approach time and responsibility.

Puzzles and Side stories

Puzzles in the game will be based on a mixture of simple rhythm-based, riddles, simple logic, and environmental puzzles. These puzzles may give further insight to the current area and what occurred. Rewarding players with new abilities that can grant more options in combat or utility.

Each section will follow the same long-term gameplay loop:



New area / Explore

This happens every time you finish a large area / story arc, each area has a new aesthetic different from the last, containing new environmental mechanics, enemies, and general designs that will make navigating or interacting with the new area unique. Before reaching the next settlement, these areas are semi-linear with a clear golden path and optional directions that challenge the player in the different ways to earn additional abilities.

New Settlement

Each settlement is a conglomerate of houses / habitats that represent the general age-demographic of the population there, mixed with the clockwork / art deco style. Basically, acting as a minor hub world for that area. The houses further act as a group of connected pathways and alternate routes with many roofs and ledges being ground for the character, thus giving more verticality, and allowing secrets to planted throughout to motivate exploration. Every settlement will have a set of core utilities (utilities found in every settlement) accompanied by some that are unique to that area, making the world feel diverse and encourage the player to revisit the area later.

Finding the Keysmith

After reaching a new area, the player will quickly figure out there is not a way to continue to ascend the clocktower as the elevator to ascend is blocked by a lock (explained later in the narrative section). These locks require a Keysmith of that area. Each Keysmith has a different way of being found (e.g. fighting to a distant house, asking around, sneaking around secure area), some easier than others, once found initiates the story line of that Keysmith.

Convince Keysmith to help

Convincing the Keysmith to help is a follow up set of quests that involves motivating the Keysmith to take responsibility and have initiative to help. These quest more strongly follow the characters and their dreams and excuses for not helping. These quests once again have variety to keep each character feeling distinct and fresh with gameplay.

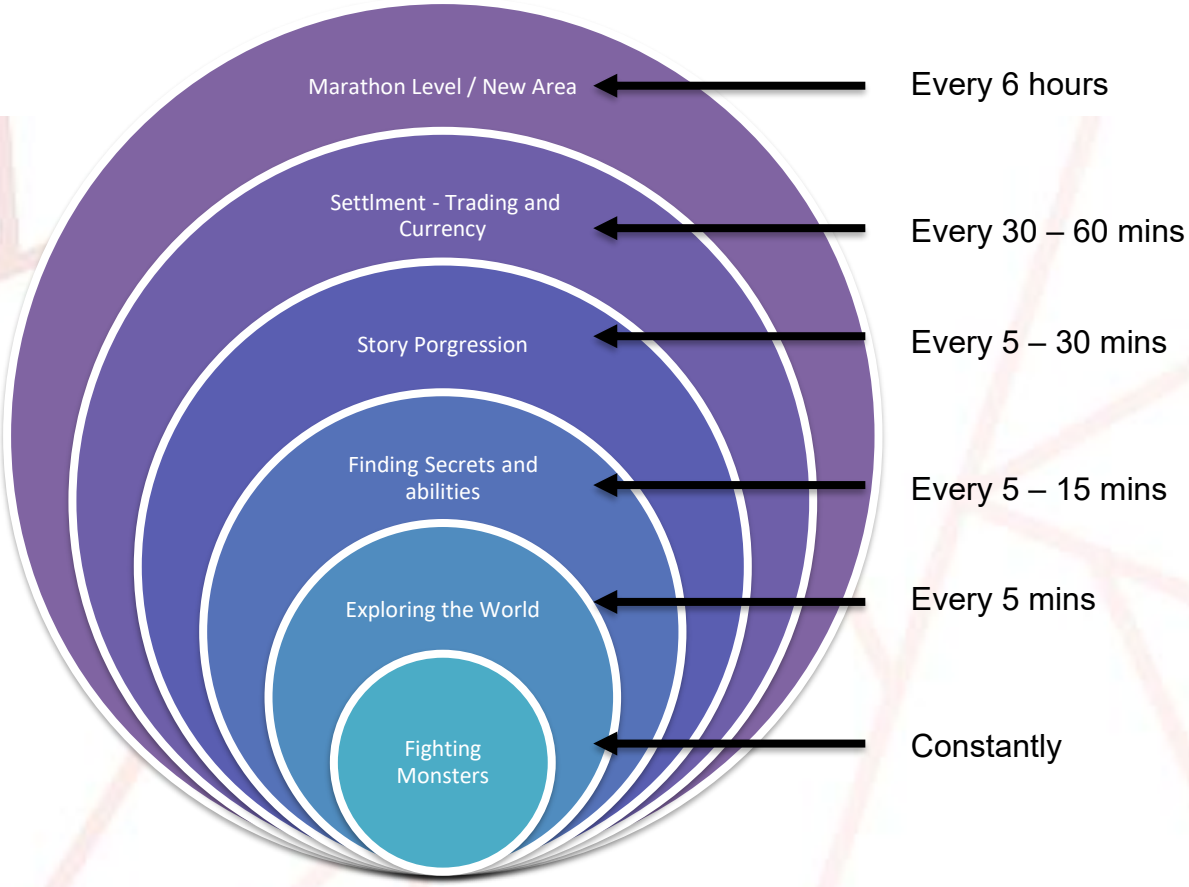
Marathon Level

The marathon level is a large portion of fast paced combat that requires you and your current Keysmith to break through several locked doors between the current and next area. This will be on a time limit meaning the player needs to be well prepared and have a solid strategy to beat the clock. The marathon levels are fully linear and have no secrets (which will be conveyed clearly to the player) so that it purely puts the skills of the player to the test. Every lock in the marathon level is surrounded by enemies which hinder progress and time. These enemies can either be killed to proceed or pushed away so the Keysmith can access the lock and move forward, the final lock requires the player fight a boss with the help of the Keysmith. Unlike the rest of the game, the player cannot die, instead taking damage reduces the timer and healing increases it. The player will be rewarded for a faster clear time.



Loop Summary

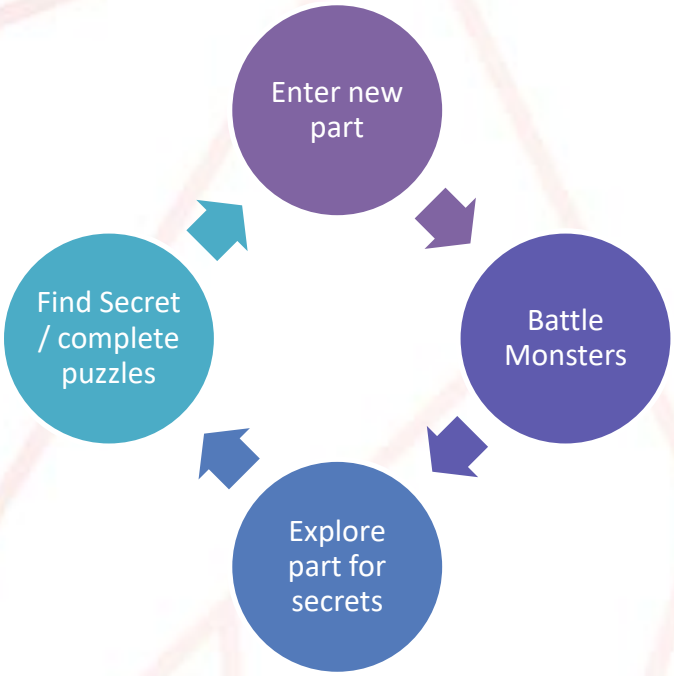
This loop balances the combat, exploration, and story elements so that the game flows and merges different genres in a natural reasonable way, this also allows for rests in between the super-fast-paced combat and small breaks from the tension in the story to allow the player to understand and refine their own strategy / kit. The diagram below further adds the frequency of certain events throughout the game to better understand the pacing of each core aspect. However, these can vary in different areas.



The diagram predicts the game to take around 24+ hours for the average player to complete, however the additional final area would take around another 1 hour or so to reach the climax. As players will likely spend around 6+ hours in a certain environment, these areas will also have sub variations and places of interest to reduce the repetitiveness of an area.

Short Term Loop

Throughout most parts of the adventure, this short-term loop will be applied, this is more centred around the larger area of the game: “exploration of the new area” The order of this loop will change for every player and their preference:



This loop is very short. Battling monsters should take no more than 5 mins per room (unless a boss) and the same goes for puzzles.

Look and Feel



The overall atmosphere will be a stylised mixture of art-deco and steampunk to blend clockwork with confident patterns. These patterns will have strong golds and brass coupled with more natural colours such as muted greens, cyan and clarets to create a vibrant blend between machine, nature, and luxury. The lighting follows a more stylised geometric approach with light cell shading to create hard-edged shadows, however the shadows themselves are not very dark and harsh to place more focus on the art-deco style.

The mood will balance a mixture of beauty (so the player feels a want to protect the world) and decay as the player see’s the beauty get destroyed. The mood will be vibrant and tranquil in some places and dark and desolate in others as the urgency shifts more and more.



The physics will not follow that of realism and will have a more stylised approach, being more rigid to fit in with the style of a clock. Due to the less floaty physics, it will be very responsive with the player being able to snap relatively quickly in different directions and have more control over their movement and precision when using certain attacks.

Monetisation Model

On launch the model will be premium with a cost of £24.99 with an optional collector's edition containing additional items such as concept art, standard art, original soundtrack (download and physical) as well as smaller items. The digital version will be at a cheaper price of £19.99. As the game progresses, depending on popularity the strategy may change to be available in places such as Xbox Game Pass and go on sale for higher discounts as the years progress onward. This is like existent games from within the genre.

Core Pillars of Design

Time

This is the main crux of the game and is the root to all other pillars. The player will constantly be reminded of the time the characters (and by extension, the player themselves) have. Most places and Proper Nouns will be based off clockwork with a story that revolves around characters and their relationship with time, for example:

- How time has changed them.
- Guilt in the way they spend time.
- Running out of time
- Having too much time



From a gameplay perspective, the player is challenged to be as efficient as possible and reduce the amount of time it takes to complete tasks and battle enemies. Time based challenges of the Marathon levels are core points in the game, coupled with rhythm-based puzzles and mechanics to support this. The main mechanic revolves around a 12 second loop that reacts differently depending on what time the player activates abilities, enforcing this pillar further.

Versatile Combat



The game will have a lot of customisations to fit how the player wants to take on the world, the only constraint is the 12 notches on the timer. There will be a vast variety of abilities with different effects (healing, damage, movement and more) that can be bound to the notches to invite any playstyle as well as a large bestiary of enemies that the player must prepare for.

Responsibility / Age / Story



The story will give strong meaning to the players actions and be centred around the other core pillars, with a focus on making the player more aware with how they spend their limited time on Earth. However, the game also investigates how different generation's view time and the ways they waste, enjoy, and spend time. Each area is a meta representation of a generation from the characters to the setting, making this theme strongly present throughout. The story also bleeds over to responsibility and initiative as the Companion encourages the Keysmiths to do what's right for the world, sacrificing their time and stability in doing so.

Preparation / Exploration



A large amount of knowledge of what the next challenge will be (e.g. certain enemies etc.) are given to the player so they can better their strategies and prepare for it. To be well prepared, the player is encouraged to explore the world to understand more about said challenges and diversify their combat timer. Furthermore, the story will involve a lot of emotional preparation for the characters to risk their lives and step out their comfort for the sake of the clocktower.

Companionship and Support



The Player character is known as the Companion and throughout the story acts as a supporting shoulder to the Keysmiths as they discover how they want to spend their time. From the worlds perspective, the player is put in the role of a side character as more focus is put on Keysmiths in hopes of conveying to the player that they are not the main character of the story (and how it is ok not to be). This is in hopes of giving the player appreciation and gratification for supporting others and taking time out of their life to do so. This shares parallels to a lot of RPG elements in other games.

Gameplay Systems & Mechanics

Combat System

This is the fundamental System in the game that dictates the flow of combat, consisting of many different mechanics and is what the character progression revolves around.

Combat Timer and Notches



The player's combat will revolve around a 12 second timer as shown. This will constantly loop throughout the player's adventure. As the player explores, they will unlock new abilities that they can equip to one of the **12 Notches.** When the timer is ticked onto a notch with an ability, the player can press a button to utilize said ability. There will be an extremely large assortment of different abilities with different powers, and some will require certain conditions. The same ability can be put on a maximum of 3 notches to allow for more extreme kits. This encourages the player to strategize and explore to find as many abilities as possible to build a versatile kit. The character will have access to all the notches from the beginning.

Abilities, Notch Conditions, Timer Deactivation

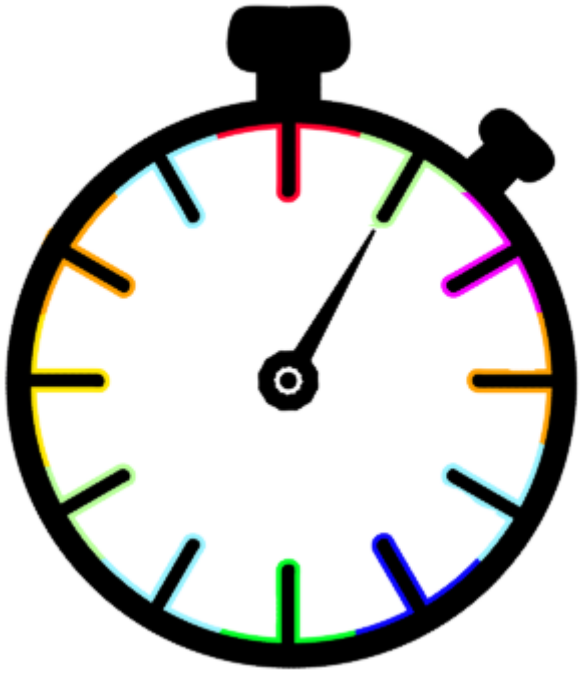
Abilities can range from healing, damage, movement, utility and even altering the timer itself. Some abilities will be significantly stronger than others thus have specific conditions or costs for using them, meaning the player must consider the risk/reward as well as bend a strategy around them.

One of these conditions is **Timer Deactivation** which means no ability can be activated for the designated number of ticks. The timer will still go forward. It is important to note that ticks and seconds are different, a tick refer to the next time the timer increments, and seconds refer to an actual whole second.

Here are some **examples of abilities** and their uses:

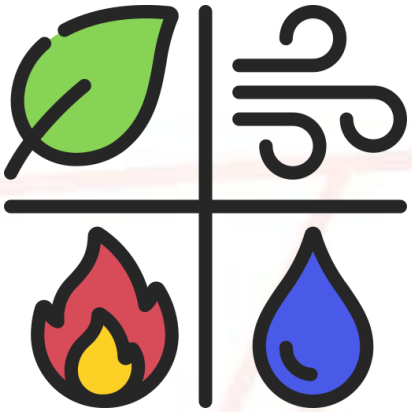
1 Second Nap **Ability:** Heals 10 hp (2 seconds) **Speed:** Instant **Condition:** None	**Time Warp** **Ability:** Slows enemy time for 3 ticks. **Range:** Full area **Speed:** Fast **Condition:** Deactivates timer for 1 tick
Mad Dash **Ability:** Heavy dash forward, knocks backs and stuns enemies for 1 tick **Speed:** Fast **Condition:** None	**Time Crunch** **Ability:** Deal Medium PHYSICAL damage in front on you **Range:** Short **Speed:** Fast **Condition:** Deactivates timer for 2 ticks.
Quarter-Hour Bumper **Ability:** Moves your dial 3 notches forward. **Speed:** Instant **Condition:** Can only be placed on notches 12, 3, 6, 9	**Power Hour** **Ability:** Increase attack damage for 12 ticks **Speed:** Instant **Condition:** Cannot be used again for 24 ticks
Half-Time **Ability:** Heals 25 hp (5 seconds), Stuns enemy time for a second. **Range:** Full area **Speed:** Fast **Condition:** Deactivates timer for 1 tick. can only be placed on notch 6. Enemies heal 3% of health.	**Paradox** **Ability:** Deal heavy RIPPLE damage in a sphere around you **Range:** Medium **Speed:** Medium-Slow **Condition:** Moves dial to a random point on timer. Deactivates timer for 5 ticks.

Here is an example of a timer with these abilities in, this would not be how the abilities are showcased in the actual game. **The dial does not move smoothly, it flicks to each notch like an analogue clock**:



Damage Types

To add an additional layer of strategy, all damage abilities have a damage type such as RIPPLE and PHYS. Enemies can be weak to these effects (meaning they take more damage) or resistant (meaning they take less damage).



The player will have ways of knowing strengths and weaknesses beyond trial and error through asking around in the settlement and reading clues in the world. This is so they can prepare and adapt their kit (this is done especially to marathon levels so they player does not feel cheated for something they could not predict).

Options beyond the Timer

To make sure the player is not solely reliant on the timer and the combat is not too repetitive, the player will have other options that are weak but still impactful if used at the right time. As the player progresses further, they will unlock other abilities:

Basic Attack (Unlocked from Start):

This is a standard 3-hit combo with the last hit knocking away smaller enemies and dealing slightly more damage. The damage it deals is small but still effective if used a lot. The basic attack can be further strengthened with additional puzzles (the places of these puzzles are known to the player).

Parry (Unlocked from Start):

The player stops and becomes invisible for an extremely short amount of time. On a successful parry (enemy hits them while parrying), the player heals 5hp (1 second) and has an opportunity to attack (enemy briefly stunned). Failing a parry leaves the player vulnerable to attacks.

Parry-Bumper (Unlocked after 1st area):

On a successful parry, the player can quickly mash button again to move the dial up to 2 ticks forward. This encourages parrying more.

Quick Bunt (Unlocked after 2nd area):

On a 10 second cooldown, the player can press a button to move the dial 2 ticks back (this does not reset deactivation time). This can be done at any time.

Quick Bump (Unlocked after 3rd area):

On a 10 second cooldown, the player can press a button to move the dial 2 ticks forward (this does not speed up deactivation time). This can be done at any time.

Second Hand (Unlocked after 4th area):

The timer gains a smaller second hand that increments every time the clock passes the 12th notch, the ability the second hand is aiming at becomes upgraded (if already upgraded, the dial will skip that notch), this can be seen in the diagram.



Marathon Specefic

Foreshadowing

Before entering a marathon level and between stasis stops, the player has the free choice to ‘foreshadow’ which tells the player: the enemies, their weaknesses, and recommended damage types to utilise. All enemies in the Marathon will be familiar to the player if they fully explored the area, apart from the gatekeeper (boss of the marathon).



Stasis Stop

A checkpoint / break in the level where the player can foreshadow, alter their timer, talk to the Keysmith, or temporarily upgrade one ability (if needed). The player can also:
Kill time – Reduces the time left on the clock in return for a greater reward.
Start the blue moon – Greater number and stronger enemies for a greater reward.

The stasis stop also acts as a fork in the road that allows player to either go the longer, less dangerous route or the shorter more dangerous route.

Settlement Systems

These are systems that will be apparent in the settlements of each area, the goal of these systems is to make the town feel more alive and functional as well as give the player more agency in the abilities they want to seek without endless grinding or rubbing against every corner for secrets.

Currency



Currency will drop from enemies once they are killed. This currency can then be used on the systems in the settlements as well as some unique abilities and puzzles. There will also be simple treasure chest that provide currency.

Rumour Mill

A windmill a player can go to and pay currency to the owner to get hints and locations of secrets they have not achieved or visited yet in the area. These hints are like simple riddles that are not overly difficult but still enough to involve some thinking.

Local Square and Townsfolk

Some townsfolk will have quests and goals that the player can help with for rewards of new abilities / cosmetics and currency. The quests will be significantly shorter than the main quests but still try to flesh out the involving townsfolk, so they feel real and alive. The local square is a slightly longer side quest that involves all the townsfolk that had quests in the area to gain one larger reward for the player (Parry Bumper, Quick Bunt, Second Hand). These quests will act as an epilogue to the local characters and area.

Horologist

The horologist acts like a forgery that the player can use currency to upgrade abilities, abilities can only be upgraded once. Upgrades can consist of strengthening damage, range, healing; reducing the conditions required for use; reducing deactivation time; adding smaller perks to the ability.

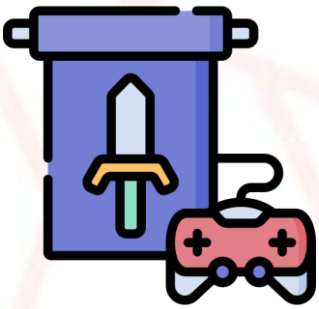
Exchange Bank

The exchange allows the player to exchange a set of abilities they do not use for ‘loyalty points’ (stronger abilities give more points). These can then be used to by new abilities. However, the player can also buy back exchanged abilities, but this will cost currency and be a lot more expensive.

Settlement Specific Quests / Utilities

To earn the additional ‘options beyond the timer’ as well as other abilities and utilities, the player must complete area-specific quests and activities that build on the worlds lore and give reason for the player to return to each settlement. The area specific utilities are small and less impactful but still useful to the player include:

- A place that allows player to switch the quick bunt and quick bump ability to other uses (e.g. quick heal or quick dash).
- A place to gamble currency for more currency and abilities.
- A challenge arena that once beaten earns the player currency.
- A place to upgrade basic attacks and parrying.



Out of Combat / Quality of Life

These are systems that help the player with quality of life and navigation of the game space, as well as contextual support of basic mechanics.

Death Rewind



For additional context, when the player dies in the game world, the game slows, the protagonist clicks the clock in their dying breath then rewinds backwards to their last save. Depending on where they died, some characters may acknowledge the player acting like they knew what was coming.

Map / Mini Map

The player will have a map that files in as they explore, this will help players with navigation of the world and will also be used to mark locations of importance by quest NPCs. Furthermore, the player can also mark places of interest themselves with pins.

Sundial / Quick Travel

Sundials will be placed sparingly across the whole game that the player can interact with, the player can instantly travel to these locations and act as save points if the player dies.

Enemy Bestiary

All enemies the player encounters will be in the bestiary, which will provide a small bit of lore to their existence as well as display the resistances and weaknesses the player has discovered.

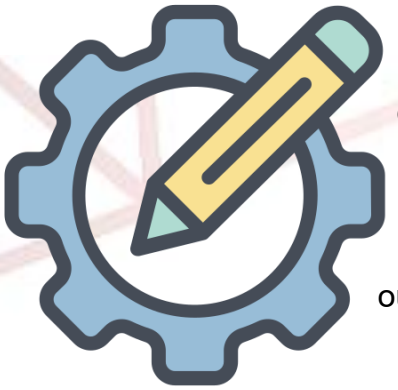
Story Log

A small log of entries that describes the story so far in a more concise way so the player can refresh themselves if they forget. This also holds the current goals and quests the player has. The player can also pin current quests to the game screen to remind them what they are after.

Timer builder menu

As there are many collected abilities, not all of them will be used, an inventory system will be put in place that the player can sort through using filters allowing them to quickly find the ability they are looking for. The timer will also have a mini menu that allows players to quickly select and append notches with abilities, as well as toggles that show the deactivation times if needed.

Timer Customisation and presets



To make easier for players to remember their own kit, players can customise their timer (notches, background dial etc.) with art-deco style patterns and text so each ability is largely distinct to them.

Also, to make it less tedious for player who enjoy multiple kits, a preset tool will be put in place to allow players to save up to 5 presets, however they will only be able to swap presets out of combat.

Narrative

Story

Background

The Mainspring Clocktower (also known as the heart of the Immortal City) is a sight to behold. A magnitude of achievement for Arborfolk of this new era of machinery and machinery only. With a bell that oscillates to the far corners of the World, the tower is the heartbeat of the city with each chime wiping the decay off the buildings and people of this beautiful era. Without warning, the clock stopped ticking.

The effects were slow but detrimental, time went on, the decay grew, the hope lost, the initiative erased. The world reached its first ever Innovative Stalemate, the Arborfolk have stopped ageing, and some would even say: ‘stopped thinking straight’.

Inside the tower reflects the former beauty before the clocktower stopped, mixed with the decay that shattered the outside. The tower has been shut off as the elevator doorways can no longer open automatically. With no one bothering to fix it, the city has divided. Nobody has gone up to clean the top of the clocktower in years. The tower is on its last legs, most Arborfolk have left. Those who are still present go about their lives in neglect of restoring their world and pass off their responsibility to others who pass it off to others. Without guardians willing to protect the Arborfolk, the tower is rampant with unstable machinery.
The player is tasked with restoring the Mainspring Clocktower to its former glory.

Introduction

Beginning cutscene of the clocktower ticking and chiming with a beautiful backdrop, it suddenly stops ticking. After a short pause, a timelapse begins to speed up showing the surrounding city and clocktower itself decay over days and days until it slows down and pans to the player character looking up at the clocktower.

The player than gains control, (currently, the game is not isometric and instead is at a 90-degree view), in which they can only walk up and talk to an Arborfolk on the verge of fully decaying, in which they say:

“I apologise for the late request; I couldn’t find the words for a while.”

“I know this isn’t your story, your struggle, your responsibility, but you possess a solution and that is what the Arborfolk need.”

“I wish I could provide more help, but I can’t even bring myself to try anymore.”

“The entrance is unlocked, good luck.”

The Arborman gives the player the timer.

They sit on the side of the pavement and wait.

The player enters and the doors shut behind them.

Game World

Setting and Tone



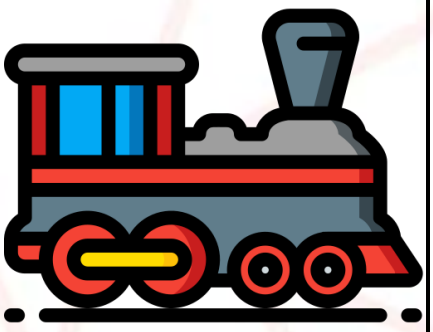
1. Reference Art of a mechanical tree, the actual game will have a similar simplified look of the bark and cogs shown.

Despite the whole game being set in the clocktower, the inside is extremely large to the point of it basically having its own ecosystem and environments. The clocktower blends a lot of natural, supernatural, and mechanical elements. Overall focusing on beauty and vibrancy to create very surreal and comforting areas. Throughout the world, elegance and precision should be at the forefront of the environment. However, the tones of decay will appear in sharp contrast containing distorted shapes and irregularity shown in the enemies and barren nature of some areas. This can create some uncanny places within the world with more decay to really run home the current problem in the game world. More tense story plots will likely start in decayed areas or decay over time to fit the mood.

Areas

This section will be broken down into the four main areas with their supporting sub areas, each is built on different forms of geometrical design and art deco as well as different uses of clockwork machinery. Each area will also convey the age demographic of the current character at the crux of the plot.

Area 1 – Central Station

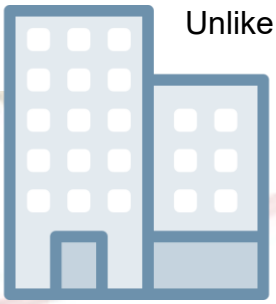


The forever station is a conglomerate of budding nature and transport-based machinery. The station was built as the entry of the clocktower to guide directionless newcomers to the stations on every floor, most commonly younger people barely into life that are seeking purpose. There has not been a departure in years as many now feel overwhelmed with their own future, constantly comparing themselves to those who have already made it. The station stretches on for a long time and contains very complex pathways.

Sub Areas Include:

- **Mainspring Central Station (Area Settlement) –** An area where each platform acts as a little home for one or two people, almost like a makeshift campsite, each home is quite different with the personality of each resident leaking through with posters and cheap scrappy decorations.
- **The greenhouse of mirrors–** Past the dark tunnels of Platform 13, an overgrown yet beautiful waiting room with a crystal floor surrounded by greenery and statues of the Arborers that built the clocktower. At the pedestal of each statue is a mirror where some residents can't help but compare themselves to the successors before them. Home of the first Keysmith.
- **The Escapement (Station Mall) –** This area is clearly what caused the overgrown environment that has developed in the station. However, instead of it being run down, it is full of different passion projects made by the previous resident, the place is a structured chaos that is powerful and beautiful. Some residents are cleaning and preserving the projects despite being very decayed themselves.
- **The Entrapment (Deeper Station Mall) –** This area shares a lot of similarity with the Station Mall but is filled with attempts of creativity by the current residents. All the pieces are unfinished, and some have been destroyed / covered up with frustration and embarrassment.
- **Platform 8 (Marathon Level) –** Heavily Locked platform that runs the train to the elevator gates, when opened, the train immediately gets ready to depart.

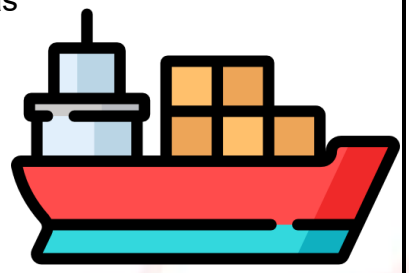
Area 2 – The Blossoming City



Unlike the last area that was overgrown, this area is more vibrant, and wildlife is more in a blossoming state, the pathways are pristine, and the small number of residents act particularly inspired and excited about their own lives. This area is a mixture of tropical and desert. Despite all this, throughout the city and around the outside, there is heavy decay, and some people are clearly much more decayed but refuse to say. The whole place resembles machinery around power, generation, and extraction.

- **Gnomon Plaza (Settlement) –** A small plaza with a large pillar (sundial in the centre) surrounded by apartments and small shops. A lot of the population is out and about, working on achieving their dreams (similar dreams to those in The Escapement). Some are more decayed and lie by the sidelines.
- **Caddy Top - Apartment 4 –** This apartment block is eight floors high with most of the apartments being completely empty. Home of the Second Keysmith. The elevator is broken, and each floor is barren and covered in sand like a desert. The flowers in the town are here but very dried out, each floor has personality indicating the person who used to live there and a puzzle around them.
- **Pendulum Promenade (Middle City) –** The outer city is a weird mixture of bright flowers and building as well as Egyptian-like ruins. Large sums of it are pretty and picturesque however small portions still contain decay. The player will visit many locations here from small libraries and markets to Karaoke, each place (although looking a bit tacky from the outside) is very pleasant inside.
- **Slums (Marathon Level) –** The slums are on the outmost part of the city, unlike the centre city, everything is very close together. This amount of sand here is at its greatest and the flowers are sparse. As more time passes, the winds get stronger, and the sands rise as if the slums are fighting against them. The Player and Keysmith must make it to the elevator fast.

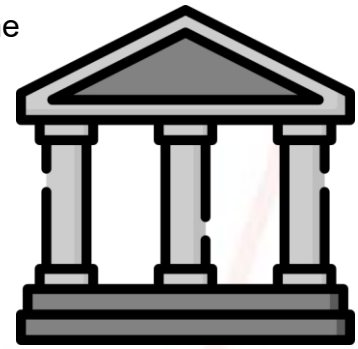
Area 3 – The Frozen Cruise Ship



This area takes place on a set of islands and a cruise ship that has completely frozen over. Unlike the last two areas, this area is far more open due to the frozen lake the ship stands in. The wildlife here has entered the stage of producing fruit, yet a lot of the nature is frosted over making it a lot more still than the previous areas. The residents don't seem to pay each other (and by extension the player) much mind unless spoken to directly, in which they will try to move you along. Everyone seems to be in an empty state of stability in which they have: settled in for jobs they sort-of like; are in houses they sort-of like; and do things they sort of like to do. All machinery represents that of a factory and manufacturing. The ship is name S.S. Pinion

- **The Hull –** This is the underbelly of the ship which is orderly filled with frozen and clunky machinery and factory workers. All the colours are very bland and cold (similar colours to an office building with the only dashes of colour being little plant life that is snuck between the machinery. Despite residents of the ship being everywhere, no one seems to be wanting to talk to you and some are gossiping and chatting among other residents while working. A slight sway is always present.
- **The Deck (Settlement)–** when the player first enters this area, it is desolate and quiet, after about 1 minute of exploring, a clock goes off signalling 5pm, shortly after all the residents come up from below and filter themselves into their houses. Despite being the largest settlement, it has the emptiest streets so far with the occasional person walking to the shops and back. Everyone seems to be inside resting, cooking oven meals or watching films.
- **Starboard Walk –** This is a walk across the side deck of the ship that overlooks all the islands and vast ocean. It is extremely grand, and the camera plays to this: tweaking the angle to show it. At the end of the walk is the **Stern** where the Keysmith is, standing on the balcony.
- **The Wreck of Pinion (46XX) –** On the Stern, there is a bang and both the player and Keysmith fall off the ship, causing a scripted death for both. The last thing seen is the engine room fully decayed. Unlike most other deaths, both the player and Keysmith are transported back in time to the ship 100 years ago. Here the ship was in it's prime with the lake not being Frozen over and many of the people on the ship seem a lot more in lighter spirits. Many people still have their hobbies and people have a bright look on the future.
- **The Engine Room (Marathon Level) –** This level acts differently to the other Marathon level as it takes place in multiple time eras of the ship. Although the architecture and layout are always similar, the design shifts to different eras of pop-culture while it catches up to the game's present day.

Area 4 – The Museum of Memories



The Museum is the final area before the main clocktower, the vegetation is coloured with light greens, golds, and browns akin to the autumn season. This area has the most decay of all however it is thinly spread throughout the whole museum and weaves quite fittingly between the pieces. The machinery (unique to only this area) has completely stopped and is presented neatly on plaques made of News Paper. The machinery of this area combines the attributes of the last three. The residents are sparse with a mix of welcoming and unwelcoming people. Most of them seem stuck in old ways and show disappointment in the displays of the museum (reflective of the younger generations).

- **The Lobby and Garden –** This lobby is deathly quiet with only the sound of your feet moving around and the writing of the receptionist (who acts very bitter to you). The architecture and art deco design are a lot more organic in its portrayal and breaks the geometric norm. The garden outside shares aspects akin to both house gardens and flamboyant castle gardens however all the trees have started losing leaves and flowers are losing their colour. Residents are very welcoming and seem to be coming from the Garden to the Museum (unlike the player who entered through the elevator).
- **The Gift Shop / Cafe (Settlement) –** A small room that opens from the lobby where the Keysmith runs a small café. The café has an extreme amount of decay surrounding it, but the centre is very honest and clean.
- **Exhibit 1: Transportation (Marathon Level) –** This area shares similarities with The Forever station however it is altered to fit the style of the lobby. Some details are vague and wrong. Overall making the area feel different and clunkily designed. The machinery and plaques describing them are very biased to older methods and show misunderstanding of how it works.
- **Exhibit 2: Power and Extraction (Marathon Level) -** This area shares similarities with The Blossoming City however it is altered to fit the style of the lobby. The flowers and machinery are made to look gaudier and tackier with plaques showing disgusts comparing the struggles of early extraction to today with it being 'much easier' and 'pointlessly showy'.
- **Exhibit 3: Manufacturing (Marathon Level) -** This area shares similarities with The Frozen Cruise Ship however it is altered to fit the style of the lobby. The flowers and machinery are made to look more faded and have a noticeable lack of pressure / power when building the other machines shown in the previous exhibits. The plaques showing disappointment in the lack of disciplinary strength to build the machines to a 'high standard' comparing it to old styles of manufacturing which was a lot more tough and rough.

Final Area – The Clocktower Bell

This area is much smaller and the climax of the game, the decay here is harsh and dark with remnants of the past areas sprinkled in ruins. There is a constant faint chiming of the bell in the distance. The whole area distorts the consistent art deco patterns and makes an uncanny and irregular atmosphere. As the player gets closer, the chimes become more sporadic until the player enters the centre bell room.

This area has one Final Marathon Level that is significantly larger followed by the final chime which causes the decay to begin to fade throughout the clocktower and the conclusion of the story to begin.

Characters

The Companion (Protagonists):



The Companion throughout the whole story is remained as a constant mystery throughout the game despite being the character the player controls. A lot of details about them are left in the dark unless the player actively searches for them.

Despite their mysterious nature, their presence alone is enough to push the narrative forward as the main characters simply need a shoulder to cry on or someone to talk to. Throughout the core narrative of the game, the Companion is always there and talked to by characters yet never directly speaks and instead occasionally performs actions that are either scripted or based on player decisions. This gives them additional layers of emotion to fit the current situation in the game. These can be small decisions of flavour (e.g. dancing at Karaoke, helping to Carry Bean Bags) or more gameplay-based decisions (Deciding what order to tackle a level, accepting side quests).

Throughout the game the player is constantly challenged by characters about why they are here and what they are getting out of the adventure. The supporting characters also help dig out lost knowledge and understanding of the Companion as their bond grows deeper.

The Companion - Greater Lore

The older generations seem to know more about the Companion than the young and they sometimes are known before even meeting people. As the player goes through this game, this is what they learn can about the Companion:

The companion was one of the only Arborfolk built without human sentience by one of the founding Arborers to simply be a listening device they can talk to. After the Arborer finished the construction of the clock tower, they felt they have peaked. The Arborer tried to create something even greater but lost pride in their work and felt they had nothing left in life to gain, despite being so dissatisfied. Furthermore, letters asking the Arborer for help piled up, everyone thought they were working on the next great discovery, it was quite the opposite. With the lack of motivation and surrounding guilt of letting people down, he locked his room for good.

Throughout the last decades of the Arborers life, they were wasted by staying inside, marinating in their self-inflicted failure, and venting out frustration with the state of the world without having the motivation to stop it. Until the day the Arborer died, the only person he ended up talking to be the Companion who sat emotionless as the Arborer decayed onto his lap. This is when the Companion gained sentience for the first time and turned to the letters to solve all the problems if not too late.

Supporting Characters (Keysmiths):

These characters own the keys to the elevators upwards. These keys are embedded into their machinery and cannot be removed. Each character here represents a different generation of people and reflect the common attitudes of their demographic.

Keysmith 1: The Uninspired

The first Keysmith is dressed like a steampunk train conductor with a mixture of pale browns, beiges, and greys, they are smaller than the Companion and seems to always be looking at the floor. On first meeting them they seem direct and blunt with words, not willing to open to the Companion. As the player follows them back to the station, they also become more defensive, in which they run off to the Escapement.



They conflict with their own purpose, responsibility, and skills, constantly spiralling about their self-worth compared to those who have achieved greatness. In which the player guides them to the Entrapment. The self-doubt coupled with the added pressure of the broken clocktower made them resign all sense of motivation and passion as they feel they will never be the hero of anyone's story, including their own.

The character is developed by the Companion helping them finish their largest and only passion project. The project is not the greatest thing in the world, but is complete, nonetheless. They come to terms with the fact that they are unique and have worth that cannot be compared to by the greats before them. Their art may not be great, but later, no matter what it turns into, it will be beautiful.

Keysmith 2: The Overwhelmed



The second Keysmith holds a more brightly coloured outfit with a lot more vibrancy (golds, cyan and clarets) interwoven into their uniform. They are dressed like a Steampunk Taxi Driver. When meeting them for the first time, they welcome you into their apartment where they are surrounded with a group of friends. They all talk to each other in high spirits and are getting ready to go out for a 'day of a lifetime'. As the day of a lifetime continues, the relationship they have with the Companion is very surface level, however around the end the group separates for the night after some 'get bored'.

This is where their true personality opens up: claiming they are so tired but so afraid to miss a second of their life. There are so many opportunities in the world, people to see, places to go and not enough time to do it all. They are so terrified to stop as they might not want to start again. Every time they are not 'living the life' they feel they are being a waste of space. This makes them hesitant to help the Companion climb the tower.

After guiding them through the city at night, they realise that it is ok to stop and take a break, and that nobody will judge them for slowing down. They have a massive hit of retrospect and look back to see if they were really 'living their best life' or instead living in someone else's dream. They also look at their future and really think about the mark they want to leave on the world. In which they help you navigate to the next floor.

Keysmith 3: The Jaded



The third Keysmith is dressed in faded business attire, the colours are like the ones of the previous Keysmith yet are very faded and riddled with muck and rust. Their stature is hunched, and they seem to pay little attention to the Companion when they first cross paths, simply walking by with not a single regard in which they are lost to crowds of people making their way home. Unlike the other Keysmiths, the Companion finds their home before finding them in which they are let in by the Keysmiths partner. Here we see their house. It is very bland and simple with little personality coming through, the cupboards are full of the same simple meals, and the furniture is worn. There is a lot of decay that looks to be growing yet ignored.

After meeting them on the balcony, this is the first Keysmith to strongly (yet politely) decline helping the Companion and does not budge of their answer, stating their reasons clearly. They have lived the same simple, stable job and day for more than half their life. They are now beyond wild risks and adventures as there are now too many strings attached to their lifestyle. They view the current adventure of the Companion as reckless, and they don't want to 'Rock the Boat' of their own world.

After confronting their past world, the Keysmith realises the hobbies and personality they sacrificed to be protected yet predictable. How still their life has been and how they have always had the chance to savour it yet chose not to. They discover there is so much more to life than work and that they can be whoever they want to be even at this age, it is never too late to make a difference.

Keysmith 4: The Reflected



The final Keysmith has a similar hunch to the previous Keysmith but holds themselves more confidently altogether. They are wearing an outfit of a steampunk Barista with rich browns, beiges, and light greens. Upon first meeting the companion, they show immediate distaste to them and clearly outline that it is not their responsibility as the eldest generation to fix the problems of the future. They challenge the Companion and younger generations to prove they are not 'faulty' in their new ways.

It is very apparent that they struggle accepting the changing ways and feel everything created by the new generations unravel the work and world their own generation built for the future. There are hints of jealousy that are covered by expectations and excuses to why it is not their adventure to be had. It is also very clear to see that they are struggling with their age and identity as the end of their life is a lot closer than the others.

After the companion and the younger generations 'rebuild' the museum, the Keysmith looks around and quickly realises how much depth there is in each individual person, and that people don't let their age define who they can and cannot be. The Keysmith then confronts the Museum resembling their generation and makes the choice to 'rebuild' their part and join the player to the top of the clocktower.

Other Characters

Lesser Characters

"Helping others is easier than helping yourself, this is because helping someone else's problems is a distraction from your own, which you are avoiding."

This is a common problem throughout every generation, and it speaks a lot of truth to how many people approach life. I want every lesser character to have this same philosophy. These lesser characters will be the ones close to the Keysmiths that will act to help or hinder the situation they are in. These can vary from the 2nd Keysmiths friends or the 3rd Keysmiths Partner. Later, these characters can be talked to for mini quests and rewards.

Horologists and Distant Characters

These characters are more background and are present to enforce the worlds narrative. The horologists help give insight in the greater world story and lore only if the player asks. Some of them have their own quests and depth however this is only if the player actively reaches for it.

Levels

Each large area, depending on the story, will have different styles of rooms and mechanics for said rooms (e.g. marathon levels, defending levels, settlements, travelling levels). Here are some examples of the different kind of settings / levels that would be present in the game world. All levels have been drawn top down however the camera will mostly be isometric.

Settlement Levels

Settlement Levels are where the game is most open in which it lays out parts of the town and utilities that the player can access. It also builds most of the environmental narrative. The can be a number of secrets in this area and it acts as a hub world for the current floor. The example shown below is the design for **Gnomon Plaza of the 2nd area:**

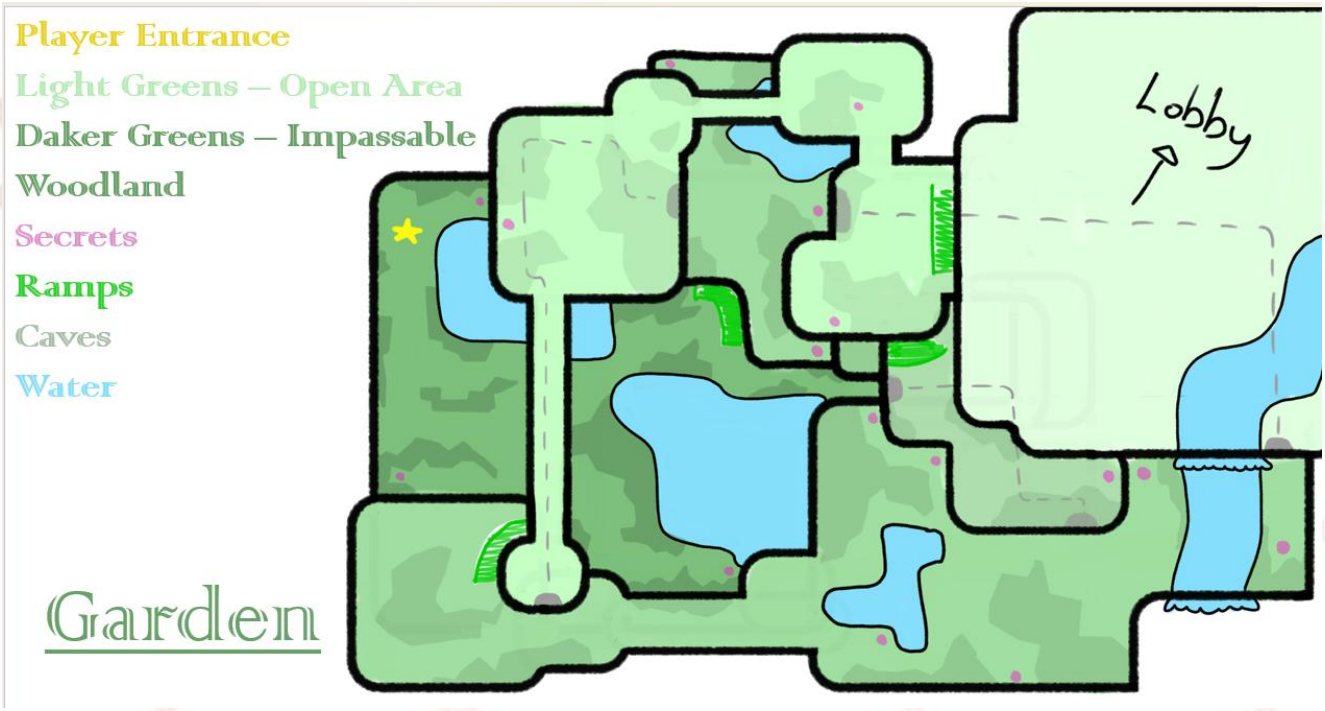


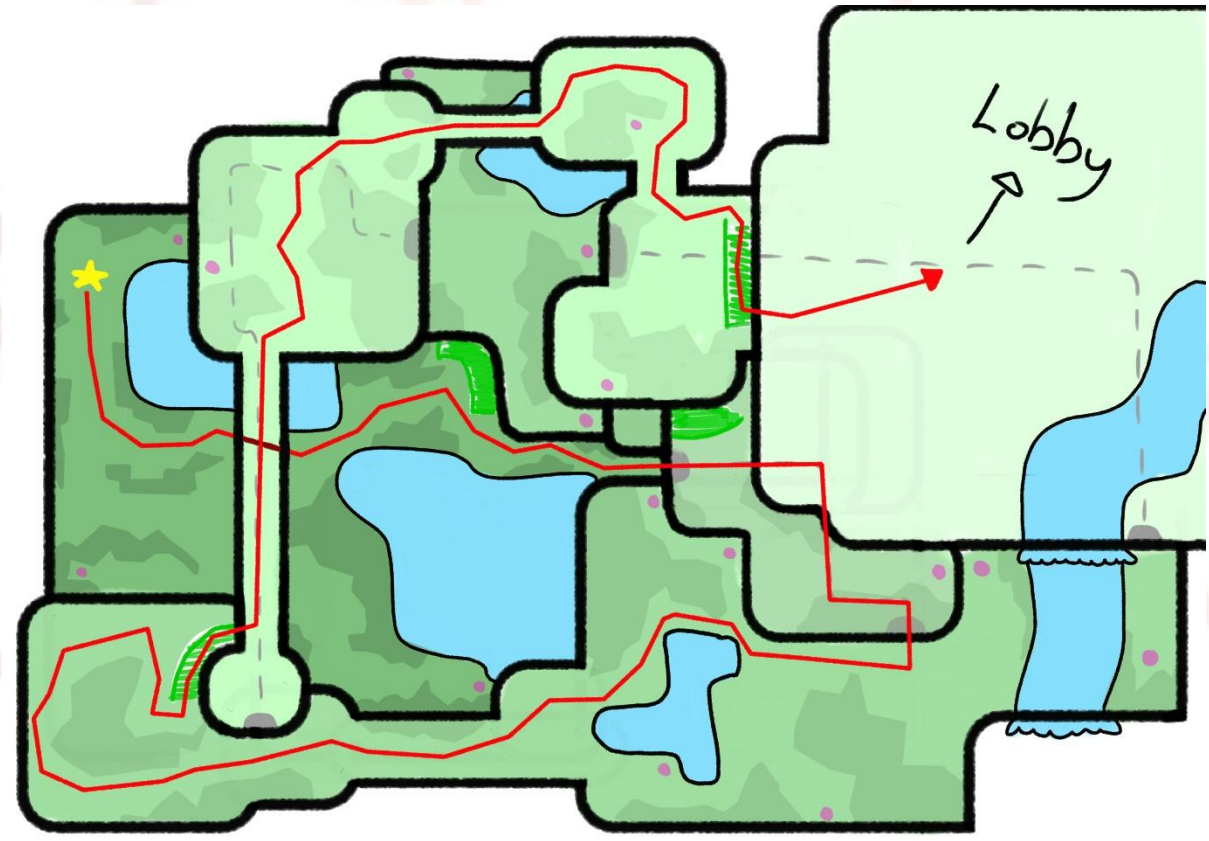
There is no critical path for this area as the path is whatever the player needs at that point. All settlements will follow the idea of containing the Horologist, Rumour Mill, Exchange Bank and Area Specific Utility, yet the areas are very different in design with layouts based on the scene and story elements needed.

Travel Levels / Areas

These areas are akin to standard isometric and adventure games where there are longer stretches of semi-linear pathways riddled with enemies and branching paths that lead to secrets and bonus rooms. This is the main crux of the gameplay for most of the areas with story-beats progress in between / throughout them. These areas allow players to find new abilities and enhance their kit. A large amount of

environmental story telling is shown here as well as the densest number of secrets. The example below is based off the **Garden and Lobby in the 4th area.**



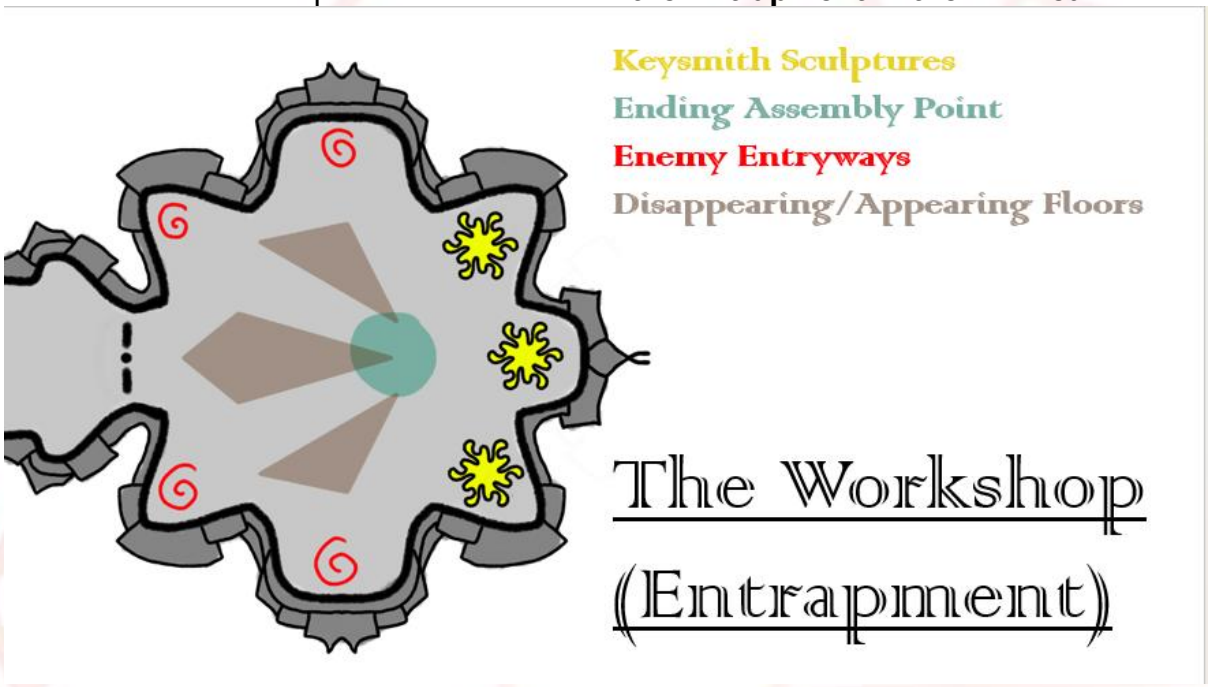


The garden here makes the player climb the different elevations to reach the lobby. Throughout the level, there are enemies that reflect the surrounding landscapes, which makes navigating it engaging and fun. The semi-linear nature means that there are multiple routes to the same end with some small branches off that reward

the player with secrets. The critical path only shows one way of reaching the goal however the player is encouraged to explore and find as many secrets and alternate pathways as possible. Throughout this area, there will also be friendly NPCs that set the scene for the new area and give further insight into what the player is and will be facing.

Defending Levels

Defending Levels are one of the more situational levels that appear in certain story beats and usually require the player to juggle combat as well as another task involving the Keysmith in question. The goal is to last until the task can be completed without the Keysmith or Player being decayed by the other enemies. Unlike the other level types, the enemies do not focus solely the player and instead switch between the Keysmith as well. These areas a small and have no secrets as they focus purely on combat. The example below is based off **the Entrapment in the 1st Area:**

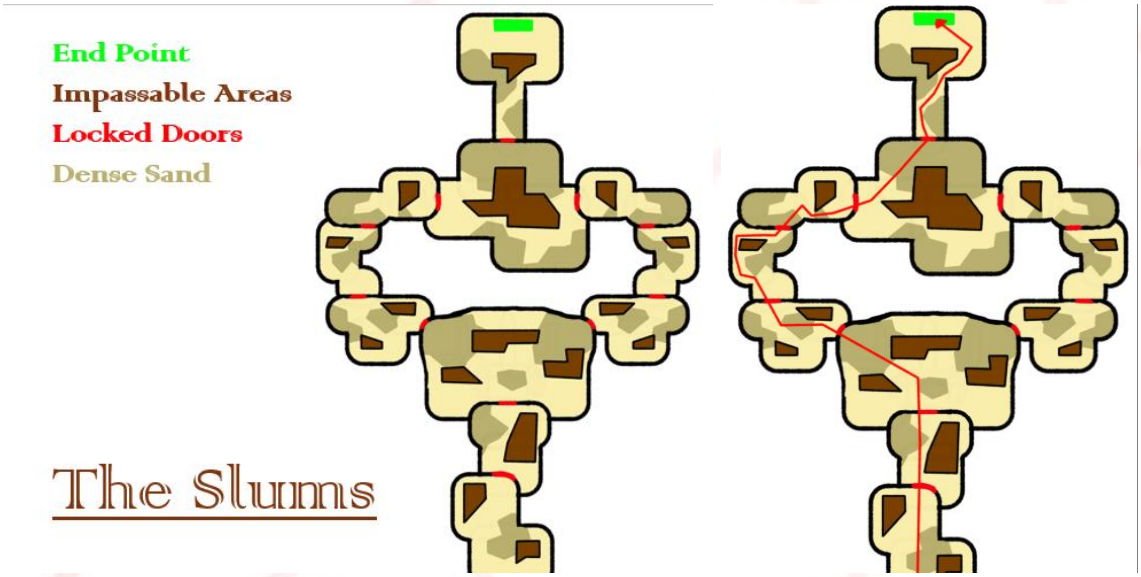


For the Workshop, the player must defend the Keysmith as they switch between and finish their 3 sculptures while decayed enemies surround them. The floors can randomly open and close providing a hazard to the player but also a way to knock enemies out of the level. During this time, the player can also spend time helping the Keysmith to speed up the time they are building at the cost of being occupied (unable to move/attack). After all sculptures are finished, the player must then defend and help push the sculptures one at a time to the centre for the final assembly, this leaves them truly open to all angles.
This puts the endurance of the player's kit to the test as they must last as long as possible without dying, the player will also know what enemies they are about to encounter giving them time to prepare for this.

Marathon Levels

The Marathon levels are the levels that focused on speed, preparation, and high-octane combat. The goal is to reach the end before the time limit expires by wading

through or killing all enemies from room to room. When the player enters a new room, the exit to the next is locked, this can be unlocked by either killing all the enemies in the room (in which the keysmith can unlock the door instantly). Or instead, they can reach the exit and place the Keysmith on the door WHILE the enemies are still alive, in which case it takes 20 seconds for them to unlock the door (unless all enemies die while unlocking). The player's health is replaced by the clock meaning taking damage reduces the time left and healing damage increases the time on the clock. These areas are extremely linear and have no secrets. The example below is part of **the Slums in the 2nd area:**



The Slums follow the narrative of the second area being set in a desert. The 'time limit' here is the rising sandstorm that picks up every time anyone goes near the elevator. Unique to this level: the dense sand does not kill the player but instead slows them down meaning the player must act fast to decipher what route is best taking. The buildings and sizes of each room vary so the player has to make the decision on the fly to either kill all enemies or immediately find the door. Alternating routes are the mirrored to give player agency without make one side easier than the other, which would lead to unfair chance. **The 'endpoint' hear would include a boss of the area.** The player would also likely be coming from a **Stasis Stop.**

Interfaces

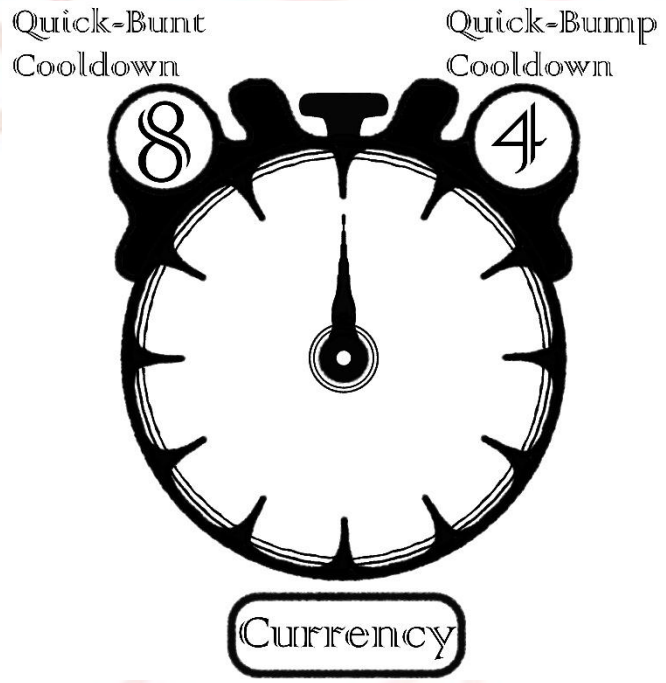
The elements discussed and their interactions with inputs will be from a console (specifically Xbox) perspective however they can be easily tailored to other Keyboard inputs and other controllers.

Game User Interface (GUI)

In Game User Interface

Most of the Game User Interface will be meta representation as well as some occasional non-diegetic elements to give the user clarity. The player's timer will be

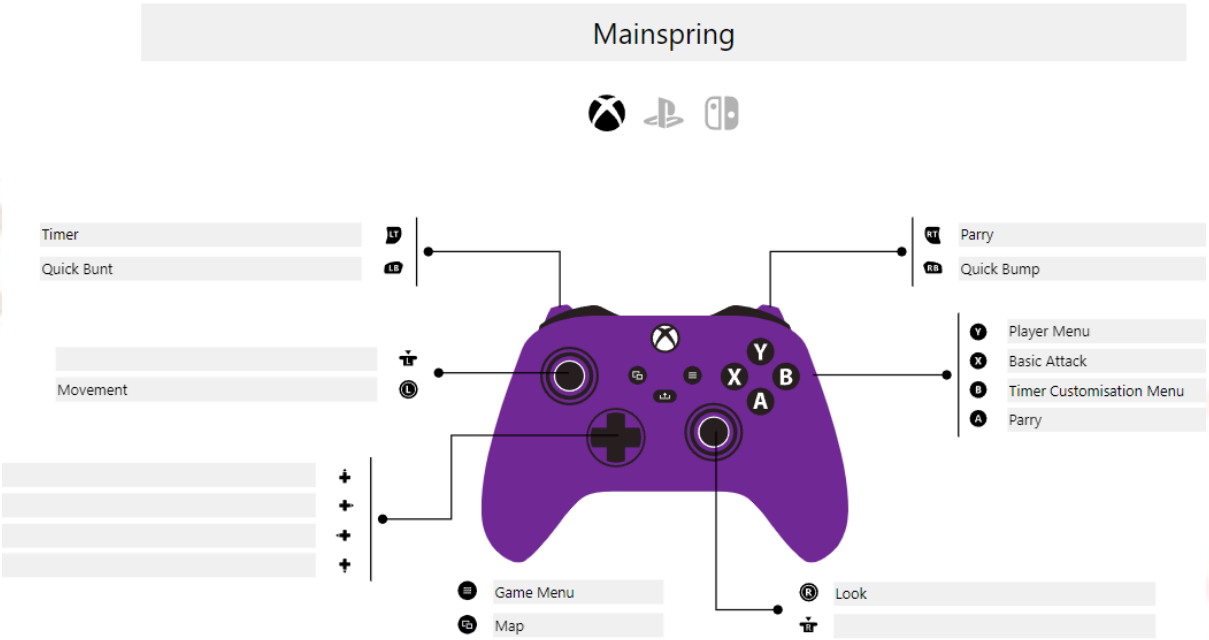
constantly shown in the corner of the screen as well as cooldowns for Quick-Bunt/Bump, Currency, and Mini-map. These will exist in the 2D space and all share similar art-styles to art deco. Below is a simple example of how the User Interface could be laid out for the timer. However, this would require testing:



Information Architecture
The menu layout will consist of 3 core menus' that the player can toggle between with the left and right bumpers. These are the **Game Menu, Player Menu, and Timer Menu.** Each have their own sub menus to help improve the player experience. There are also certain buttons that pull up specific menus quickly and make navigation smooth. **The navigation diagram is shown at the end of the document.**

Input Controls

This is the potential control scheme of the game. These controls prioritise using the triggers and X / A / triggers / bumpers to allow fast, easy-to-reach actions during combat while placing the more situational buttons further from the common grip but still not inconvenient if needed in a short time. The parry button also has two placements as this is dependent on the player's preference and all buttons can be re-bound in the binding's menu.



If the possibility arises, the player may also be able to use the D-Pad to bind other useful options such as direct presets however this would be dependent on the state of the gameplay.

Audio

Almost all the sound effect audio apart from menu navigation is diegetic, this is so the player stays immersed in the character of the Companion. These sounds will have reverberations, attenuation, and occlusion very akin to metallic and brass instruments with large echoes throughout the clock tower and very hollow footsteps that reverb throughout the environment.

This is except for the music that can only be heard by the player. The music is adaptive to the current situation of the Companion. When out of combat, the music is more relaxed and peaceful. When entering combat, instruments are added to the music to make it more action centric in which they fade out after combat is done. The music will have a fine mix between elegance and beauty (mimicking art deco) and brass with percussion (mimicking steampunk), these will interweave to flow naturally into one another.

Accessibility

To accommodate for all players skill levels and disabilities, there will be additional options such as colour-blind modes and ‘auto-lock’ on that put less strain on those with physical disabilities. An additional ‘Story Mode’ and ‘Arborer (Hard) Mode’ will be added beyond the default to allow for players to get what they want out of the game. Arborer Mode will preface that no additional story elements will be added however there will be an achievement for completing it.

For those with hearing impairments, visual indicators can be turned on to provide subtle yet impactful visual help with some sections of the game.

Some characters might share similar attributes to real-world mental health disabilities, the writing will be carefully considered and reviewed by those who share similar conditions with those in the game, so the writing is not presumptuous / disrespectful, and instead accurate to reality. The goal of the writing is to validate these conditions and make these demographics feel seen.

Technical

Release Platforms

On release, the game will look towards Xbox (both Xbox One and Xbox Series X) and PC (Steam) and then will later move to other consoles such as PlayStation and Nintendo Switch if the game is well received.

Hardware Requirements

PC Requirements:

- OS: Windows 10
- Processor: Intel i5 Quad-core, 3 GHz.
- Memory: 8 - 16 GB
- Storage: 3GB Available
- Direct XDX12
- Graphics: GTX 1080 / RX VEGA 64

Development Hardware & Software

Hardware

PCs will be provided that contain at least minimum requirements for the game to run. Furthermore, drawing tablets, audio recording equipment / facilities and additional equipment should be provided to meet the needs of every department. This can be done as the game will not involve an extremely large studio.

Software

The game will be developed using Unreal for its robust particle system and free-to-use availability. The game will place large focus on the 3D visual and stunning yet stylised look which Unreal is more than capable to provide, furthermore it is open source allowing for tailoring to the project.

For modelling, Blender provides many different tools. Acting as both a technical modelling software and sculpting modelling software, it is capable of a lot for it being a completely free-to-use software. Furthermore, the graphics won't be geared towards hyperrealism so there is no need to worry about some detail limitations.

2D illustration will likely fall onto Photoshop due to its renowned presence as an industry standard meaning many are familiar with it, however Krita can also be used as an alternative as it is free and can utilise .PSD files making it amazing for a lower budget project.

For narrative structuring and storyboarding, utilising Excel and Miro are good for covering both visual and logical approaches to narrative structuring.

Information Architecture Diagram

